## COUNTY BRIDEWELLS

LAVENHAM. A workroom below: a chamber for men; only one room for women: none of them secure. The prison is out of repair. At a former visit I heard that a prisoner had escaped, for which the keeper was fined, though the neglect lay in the magistrates. Two more, lately escaped through the plaster wall. Prisoners always kept within doors; the court not secure: no water: no straw. Keeper's salary, £15 14s. 8d. No fees. Employment, spinning wool. There is no proper separation of female prisoners. An old outhouse and stable of the keeper's might be made convenient for them. At my last visit, I found the magistrates had sent to the keeper a number of thumb-screws for securing prisoners.

CLARE. A workroom. Two lodging-rooms with boarded bedsteads. No chimneys. The workroom close glazed, and made offensive by a closet in it. No court. Prisoners have no access to the well of fine water. The prison is thatched, the walls are clay, but the men's lodging-room boarded; and the whole of it is ruinous: the prisoner in 1776, a woman, at work, in irons. No allowance. Each prisoner pays a penny a day for straw, etc. Keeper a weaver: salary, £13 13s. 4d.: no fees. Clauses against spirituous liquors not hung up. At my first visit in 1779, the three prisoners, though they were women, had each a heavy chain, and the two impressed men had chains and logs. No justices have visited this prison for many years.

# MIDLAND CIRCUIT

## WARWICKSHIRE

### COUNTY GAOL AT WARWICK

"The felons were sadly crowded. Only one small day-room for the men; and I saw thirty-two lay chained in a dungeon of twenty-two feet diameter, down thirty-one steps; two of whom were ill of a slow fever.[1] There were three others in a room, very ill, and in irons. In two rooms (seven feet and a half by six and a half) with apertures only in the doors, there lay fourteen women, almost suffocated."

[From *An Account of Lazarettos*, p. 158.]

### COVENTRY CITY AND COUNTY GAOL

This gaol, built about 1772, is in a close part of the city. I was shown a fine spot which some gentlemen very judiciously preferred. It has eight lodging-rooms for master's-side debtors; and the common ward. Women felons have only one room, and that without a fire-place. The men have a day-room. To their dungeons there is a descent of twelve steps to a passage only four feet wide: the four dungeons are about nine feet by six: at the upper corner of each, a little window, eleven inches by seven. All are very damp, dirty, and offensive: we went down with torches. Only one court for all prisoners. No straw: no infirmary: no bath. Rooms might be made for criminals in the area where the old county hall stood; in which case, the horrid dungeons need not be used, and the sexes might be separated. Neither clauses against spirituous liquors, nor the Act for preserving the health of prisoners, are hung up.

[1] Before the convicts went off, who lately were ordered to Plymouth, this dungeon was so crowded that some of the poor wretches were forced to stand up (and take a sort of miserable night watch) while the others slept. From the aperture of this dungeon (which is three feet three inches wide) as from the door and the two funnels of the dungeon in the gaol at Stafford, the steam of the prisoners' breath comes out, in winter, like the smoke of a chimney.